These days, in which our leaders publicly blame each other for decisions they deem inappropriate or for unsuitable appointments to the most senior positions in the defense establishment, it is right to acknowledge the entire set of Yitzhak Shamir's practical considerations when it came to appointing a new head of the Mossad. I was told at the time, albeit not by him, but by a close associate of his whose words I have no reason to doubt, that the prime minister, in explaining his reasons for not appointing Amnon Lipkin-Shahak, said that had he appointed him as head of the Mossad, he as prime minister and the State of Israel in general would be losing a worthy candidate to be the IDF's next chief of staff. Of course, Amnon was indeed appointed as the next chief of staff, and this was a blessing for Israel.

Leaders tend to be suspicious people. Suspicion is a necessary trait in politics. I know this from the experience of working with three prime ministers. But as far as my relationship with Yitzhak Shamir was concerned, I quickly gained his trust and enjoyed every minute of working with him. The most important element in the head of the Mossad's relationship with the prime minister is mutual trust, and the support given by the prime minister to the Mossad director. A lot of sweat, and sometimes blood, goes into building this trust and support. Bad decisions and mistakes in execution can bring about colossal damage, diplomatic and otherwise. A Mossad head who feels that he is receiving only limited backing from his prime minister will hesitate to take risks, and this will have an immediate effect on the quality of the achievements and results of the intelligence effort. In my working relationship with Prime Minister Shamir, I was absolutely certain that if and when I needed him or his support, in successes as well as in failures, he would have my back. He was always there!

In April 1987, Shimon Peres, then foreign minister in the unity government, reached what was known as the London Agreement with King Hussein. Peres, who advocated the idea of an international conference to advance the peace process between us, Jordan, and the Palestinians, concocted a plan for such a conference, purportedly initiated and to be sponsored by the United States. When Peres returned from London and presented the agreement to Prime Minister Shamir, the latter completely rejected it. The rationale behind such a conference stood in stark contrast to Shamir's political outlook at the time.